



Shadowing Neeraj: Sachin Yadav's 84.39m throw was one of the biggest highlights at the Games. RITU RAJ KONWAR

multi-purpose hall and a renovated athletics track.

Although these facilities were to some extent rushed — the equipment at the shooting range in particular was being installed just a few hours before the start of the competition — the fact remains that these same venues would witness some impressive performances by Indian athletes.

There were enough storylines for fans of Indian sport to look back on. In the men's javelin throw, Sachin Yadav announced himself as a potential heir to Neeraj Chopra with a world-leading 84.39m throw, although he looked good for a much bigger mark, having cleared around 86m in a warm-up attempt. At just 20 years old, Madhya Pradesh pole vaulter Dev Meena (**right**) improved on the national record by 0.01m to finish at 5.32m, and looked set to add several more inches by the end of the year. Animesh Kujur's breezy 100m and 200m double suggests he should be taking a crack at the Indian

national record very soon.

There were impressive numbers posted at the shooting range too, with Ashi Chouksey (598/600) and Aishwary Pratap Tomar (597/600) notching qualification scores in excess of the world record in the women's and men's 50m three-position category, respectively.

While both Ashi and Aishwary are established shooters, a number of athletes used the National Games as a springboard to national recognition. Nineteen-year-old Suruchi Phogat continued to post top scores in the women's 10m air pistol — shooting her third straight competition score above 585 (for perspective, the highest score in qualifying at the Olympics was 582) and then following it up with a dominant performance in the final. Jonathan Anthony, just 15, stunned a number of elite shooters, including Olympic bronze medallist Sarabjot, in the men's 10m air pistol competition to become the youngest shooting gold medallist at a National Games.

